

The Arts and Craft Movement.



William Morris

1834-1896



https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TgctzHOLcoY



ACTIVITY 1 - Starter:











Symmetrical vs. asymmetrical patterns, types of lines, specific colors used, texture or surface quality

Record your thoughts… **SEE, THINK, WONDER**



Individually record your observations:

'What do I see?',
'What do I think about this?',
'What does it make me wonder?'.
"Why do you think Morris chose to use natural forms instead of geometric shapes?
What does 'handmade' look like in a finished product?"

Prompt: Specifically focus on materials, patterns, and production methods.

Group Discussion:

What common elements are you noticing across these different objects?

What might these shared features tell us about the movement's beliefs?

Main Information on Arts and Crafts Movement

The Arts and Crafts movement was a **late 19th-century** reaction against the **negative effects of the Industrial Revolution**, such as **mass production** and **poor working conditions**. It sought to **revive traditional craftsmanship and elevate the decorative arts**.

Core principles:

- **Handmade is better than machine-made.** The movement valued the unique character and quality of things made by hand.
- **Beauty and function should be combined.** Every object, from a chair to a teapot, should be both useful and beautiful. It rejected excessive, pointless decoration.
- **Respect for materials.** Designers used natural, local materials and let their inherent qualities shine through, such as the grain of wood or the texture of clay.
- **Simplicity and honesty in design.** Objects had clean lines, and their construction was often visible, like exposed joints in furniture. This was a protest against the "dishonest" mass-produced items that hid their shoddy construction.
- **Art for everyone.** The movement aimed to bring art into everyday life and believed that beautiful objects should be accessible to all people, not just the wealthy. Unfortunately, the high cost of handcrafted goods often made this difficult to achieve.
- **Joy in labor.** It championed the idea that workers should find pride and satisfaction in their craft, connecting the designer and the maker. This was a direct contrast to the dehumanizing, repetitive tasks of factory work.

Activity 2: The Ideals of Morris (10 minutes)

Research and discuss the philosophical motivations behind William Morris's design and production methods, connecting these to his critique of industrialisation.

Morris quote:

"Have nothing in your houses that you do not know to be useful, or believe to be beautiful."

TASK: Research the context of the quote, specifically looking for information on Morris's views on craftsmanship, the machine, and social reform.

Discuss your findings, **relating** them back to the **objects analysed in Activity 1**. "How does this philosophy connect to the way these objects look and were made? What was Morris advocating for?"

TASK: Create a mind map or a cause-and-effect diagram on the digital whiteboard, linking Morris's ideals (cause) to the characteristics of his designs (effect).

'why' not just the **'what'**. "Was Morris against machines themselves, or what machines were being used for? What problems did he see with products made in factories?"

Key words: Utopian, Socialist, Craftsmanship, Industrial Revolution.

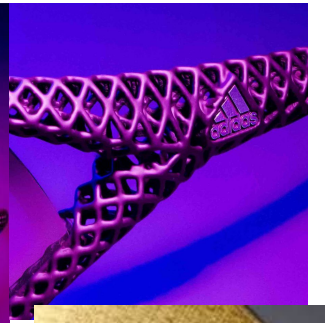
Activity 3: Arts and Crafts in the 21st Century

William Morris's methods and principles - evaluating contemporary product designs















- How does this product's design or production method align with or contrast against William Morris's principles?
- What trade-offs were made?
- What would Morris think of this design, and why?
- How are William Morris's ideas about sustainability or ethical production still relevant to modern design specifications?
- When is 'handcrafted' a valuable design choice, and when is it not?"

Assessment/Exit Ticket

Werner Aisslinger's 2012 'Hemp' chair commercialised the idea of a monobloc chair made from sustainable materials. This version is made in a similar way to rear parcel shelves in cars but uses hemp.



https://www.designdaily.com.au/blog/2015/11/the-search-for-the-sustainable-chair

Select one specific product from a **contemporary designer** or brand. Using your knowledge of the **Arts and Crafts movement**, **analyse and evaluate** how the product's design, materials, or production methods either reflect or reject the principles of **William Morris**. **Justify your answer** and **explain why understanding this historical context is important for a contemporary product designer.**

***Exemplar Response** from AI to help youtube started:*

It would identify key Arts and Crafts principles (e.g., emphasis on natural materials, visible craftsmanship, ethical production) and show how they are reflected in the chosen product. The response would also discuss how the modern example may differ (e.g., using digital tools for initial design) while maintaining the core ethos. The final part of the response would explicitly connect this historical understanding to contemporary design considerations, such as a designer's responsibility for sustainable sourcing, product lifecycle, and the ethical treatment of workers, tying the past directly to the present.